

8.2 Know your message ↕

To be able to provide a clear and succinct explanation of the insights that have emerged from the data, it is important that you understand the data well. This means that you need to be able to explain:

- what the data means to the audience you are communicating with
- what limitations are inherent in the data
- how these limitations impact the insights.

It is important to remember that the goal is to enable the audience to make better decisions. Therefore, in addition to understanding the audience, you need to understand what types of insight will assist the decision maker/s and improve their decision making.

What helps the decision maker

Often, there are multiple quantitative and qualitative factors that a decision maker must take into consideration when making a decision. Additionally, the decision maker is likely to:

- need to be aware of the impact the decision will have on various stakeholders
- have incomplete information on which to make the decision
- have to make the decision within short time constraints.

All this must be considered when developing a data visualisation. As a result, the insights that are visualised must be clear and easy to interpret within a short time frame. Visualisations must have a high data-ink ratio and be free of chart junk.

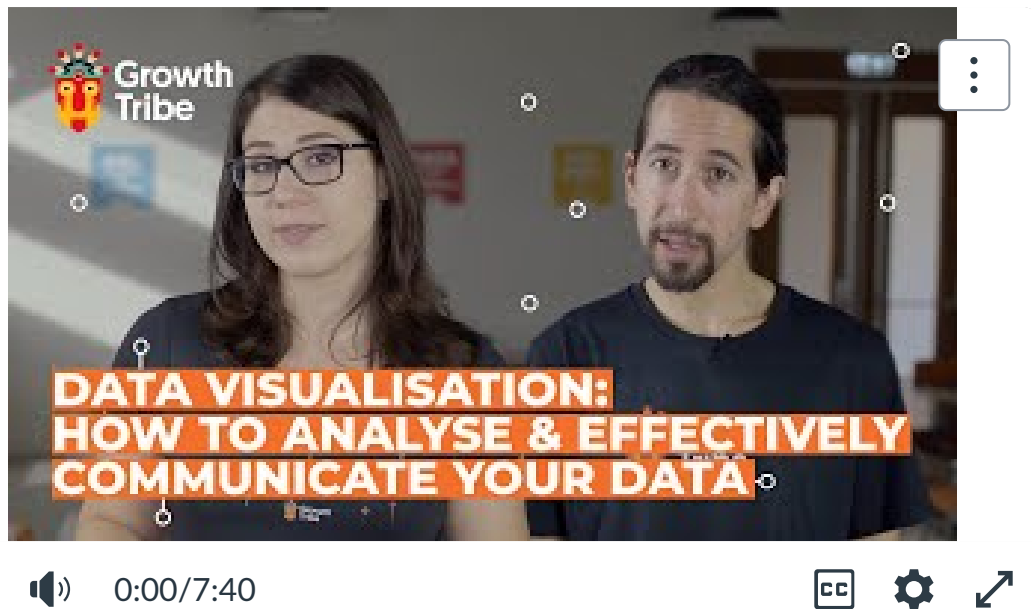
Understanding the types of decisions that will be made is important.

□ Watch: Data visualisation [7.39 mins]

This video explains why data scientists need to be excellent storytellers. This is useful as it describes the need for combining data, visualisations and a great narrative in cohesive communication which can support audience decision making.

As you watch consider:

- How can being able to incorporate data and visuals into a story improve audience engagement and outcomes, such as tangible business impacts?
- Why can a data story be a useful support for strategic decision making?



Source: © Growth Tribe (2019).

Empathising with data

Empathy is about understanding and sharing in the feelings of others. Data is not just numbers from a spreadsheet or database. Data often represents real people, and decisions based on the insights gleaned from data visualisation may impact the livelihoods of people. Therefore, it's important to consider how visualisations can be created to help generate empathy and thus impact decisions.

□ Watch: Explaining visually to influence with data (part 2) [11:32 mins]

Watch the following video, which explains how the effectiveness of a message can be increased by utilising empathy, in varying ways, in the creation of a visualisation.

This is useful as it provides a fundamental understanding of the importance of being able to empathise with data.



[Transcript](#)

(<https://learn.usc.edu.au/courses/35242/files/3138522?wrap=1>)

Source: © University of the Sunshine Coast (2023).

Download the following slides for note taking: [ICT702 Explaining visually to influence with data \(part 2\)](https://learn.usc.edu.au/courses/35242/files/3167608?wrap=1) (<https://learn.usc.edu.au/courses/35242/files/3167608?wrap=1>)

There are two common challenges with creating visualisations to help generate empathy.

1. **Audiences can lose the ability to associate meaning with large numbers.** It is difficult to understand and visualise the relative sizes of large numbers. In general, people can only visualise groups containing up to about 100 items. The following strategies may help:
 - Convert the number into something more familiar to the audience.
 - Avoid using exponential (or scientific) notation; use the words instead (e.g. millions, billions).
 - Use a chart type in which the context of the data can be highlighted (e.g. a dot matrix chart that includes perspective).
2. **When aggregate statistics are used, individual cases are difficult to consider.** Including a focus on the individual makes the numbers more relatable. For example, use images, individual (fictitious) case details or user personas which include a name and defining characteristics.

□ Watch: Creating empathy with data visualisation
[22.48 mins]

This webinar recording provides a useful insight into the work of a data visualisation designer. The video emphasises the importance of portraying empathy in visualisations.

As you watch, consider:

- How could you include empathy in the data visualisations you create?
- Why would the inclusion of empathy in your data visualisations make them more interesting?



Source: © Institute for War & Peace Reporting (2020).

□ Activity: Visualising the composition of blood

Reflect on this webpage about the composition of blood.

As you look at the visualisations, consider and make notes on:

- how well the first visualisation delivers its message
- whether the first visualisation generates empathy
- if the empathy in the first visualisation could be improved how could that be done
- how the first visualisation could be improved.

Explain your reasoning and bring your notes to the workshop.

Belan, M., & Bhutada, G. (2022, October 29). [Visualising the composition of blood](https://www.visualcapitalist.com/visualizing-the-composition-of-blood/)  (<https://www.visualcapitalist.com/visualizing-the-composition-of-blood/>).. *Visual Capitalist*.

